

technology to assimilate into a collective, or rather, many collectives...

Let's look closer at the similarities and differences that exist between us and the Borg.

ENHANCED SENSES

The Borg have enhanced senses, such as seeing, adapting to changes, learning as a collective, and generally being far superior to a Drone's original life form. A Borg Drone is nothing but an individual entity that is controlled by the hive mind.

There are a lot of us who consider the first humanoid to pick up a pointy stick to assist him or her in survival – probably when under attack from a wild animal – to be the first “person” in the history of earth to use technology. Not just that, but there would have been myriads of such events, such as discovering fire, the slingshot, bows and arrows, spears, learning how to cook meat... the list is endless... and you could consider all of that technology... but not us. We're geeks not anthropologists or archaeologists, so we don't really care too much about ancient history for the purposes of this cover story. For us, technology is exactly what we call technology today, even if today's technology will only be considered the sticks and spears of the days to come...

For us, the first calculating machines are the beginning of our journey towards becoming the borg. Giving us the ability to do mathematics much faster and more accurately than ever before. No matter if you were terrible at math, or a certified genius, with a calculator, we can all be just as fast when it comes to finding the square root of 4,072,324 (which is 2018). Now you or I might both get that right, or wrong, depending on how our brains work, or what state they're in (brains don't work as well when exhausted or sleepy). However, a calculator will just always output the right answer.

Of course a machine can be broken, and thus may output the wrong answer, but then it usually shows errors and will just break down, or get even simple answers wrong. So you could ask it the square root of 400, and it

would say something other than 20 if it was malfunctioning. Besides, you could always use machines to check the work of other machines, and set in several levels of redundancies, and still be far faster at getting correct answers to complex mathematical questions than almost all humans can achieve.

Now if we start using such a technology as a tool, and incorporate it into our lives, we've essentially added cybernetic capabilities to ourselves. Read Robert's editorial on Page 1 to understand why we're considering technology use to make us something like cyborgs.



Bet you never thought this thing made you a cyborg did you?

In this way, we feel that technology has been enhancing some of our senses and abilities for quite some time now. Cameras, telescopes and microscopes give us the ability to see what we would not otherwise have been able to. Microphones and earphones give us the ability to hear things other than what's just around us, and only what's in our rather limited frequency range of hearing ability. You can think of ways in which we humans have been enhanced sensorily across all our senses – touch, smell, sight, sound and taste. However, that's just the five basic senses, it's in the field of intelligence and the enhancing of the brain's ability that technology has really made a mark. We will come back to that later in this covery story though.

DULLING OF EMOTIONS

Another feature of the Borg as depicted in *Star Trek* is the dulling of emotions, or the absolute removal of all emotions. Although many believe that most people are getting too emotional, and it's why words such as “snowflake” are often thrown about as insults online, most psychologists believe that it is the opposite that is true.

Because the developed world is becoming a society of phone obsessed and instant gratification seeking youngsters, we're also seeing an increased inability to communicate effectively with one another. We're just so used to screens and online communication, we're stuttering and failing at real world interactions. And this is not something I'm making up, it's a large group of psychologists who say that.

Not only is technology (in the form of social media, or YouTube, or just the smartphone in general) breeding a lack of empathy by cutting down real world interactions between people, it's also causing more anxiety in teenagers, which then results in even more focus on self, and even less focus on others... it's a vicious cycle, and if it progresses into addiction, it can get overwhelming pretty quickly.

Although we don't have a Borg-like unemotional existence, who is to say that the original species of the Borg didn't start off in the same way, and gradually worked its way up into a complete killing off of emotions as expendable weaknesses?

ASSIMILATION

“Resistance is futile.” So say the Borg when they encounter someone they want to assimilate into the ranks, which is their primary purpose of existence. They're relentless and keep pushing to assimilate everyone into their fold. Sound familiar?

These days everything seems almost binary – something we've written about before as well. Every single issue has become a question of either for or against, and there's no middle ground and nuance left in discussions. With what aim though? Both sides of an argument want to attack those who think differently from them and either seduce them into a conversion, or brow